

THE SIMPLE AGENDA

(A MANIFESTO OF HOPE)



For A Better
Tomorrow

Pastor Dr. Osagie Ize-Iyamu Esq.

©2024

OUR VISION:

To make Edo State a model for the country.

OUR MISSION:

To fast track the transformation of Edo state through transparent, effective and accountable governance that will improve the living standards and social well being of our people.

Preamble

My dear Edo people, I respectfully greet you and wish you a prosperous year 2020.

In 2005, I and a few others formed the **Action Congress (AC)**. It was on this platform that Comrade Adams Aliu Oshiomhole contested for the office of governor of Edo State in 2007 and was sworn-in after a

protracted legal battle in 2008. Afterwards, the party metamorphosed twice into the **Advanced Congress for Democrats (ACD)** and then the **Action Congress of Nigeria, (ACN)**.

I was privileged to serve as the National Vice-Chairman of the ACN, South-South zone and was a member of the party's National caucus. In 2012, I was appointed the Director-General (**DG**) of Comrade Adams Aliu Oshiomhole's second term re-election campaign and our party won in the 18 Local Government Areas of Edo State.

As one of the few who pioneered the move for the merger of the **ACN** with other political parties, I was a member of the merger committee and functioned simultaneously as the Vice-Chairman of the Constitution drafting committee before the final registration of the party, **All Progressive Congress, (APC)**, on the 6th of February, 2013.

After a lingering crisis arising from party congresses in 2014, I exited the party and joined the People's Democratic Party, (PDP). The first edition of the **SIMPLE** Agenda was published in 2015 when I decided to contest for the governorship of the state in 2016.

Arising from our interaction with leaders of the APC at both national and state level on the need to return to the party coupled with our disenchantment with the lackluster attitude of the PDP leadership in Edo state which was inimical to our objective and vision, we decided to revert to the APC.

My fellow Edo people, we have never hidden the fact that our primary objective in politics is to access government for the benefit of our people and we are confident that the party offers the best platform to represent them, while pursuing and actualizing their interest.

This year is vital, because it marks the end of the eight-year rule of an administration that came on the wings of so many promises and offers us an opportunity of electing a new government that has the capacity to manage the affairs of the state and change its fortune for the better.

This change that Edo people desire is not one based on empty sloganeering or deceit. In every facet, Edolites yearn for change that is real, life-enhancing, verifiable, purposeful, and sustainable. In lieu of this, we have analyzed the current challenges facing our state, consulted widely across the 18 Local Government Areas, and on the basis of the APC manifesto, we have come up with a robust blueprint to launch Edo State on the path to sustainable prosperity and holistic development. Ours is a genuine road map to transform our state from its present unacceptable condition of underdevelopment to an attractive State with a vibrant economy. The blueprint, code-named the "**SIMPLE**" Agenda (**2nd Edition**), offers measurable commitments that will be implemented with passion, single-mindedness, as well as incisive competence and experience.

The **SIMPLE** Agenda is **SMART**. It is:

Specific

Measurable

Accurate

Reliable and

What are the issues?

Any government that intends to bring real advancement and prosperity to its citizens must focus on a comprehensive and sustainable development plan that encompasses the improvement of infrastructure, health, education, human resource development, job creation, industrialization, agriculture, security and the refinement of municipal services such as the provision of clean, portable water and electricity. Unfortunately, over the past seven years, Edo state government has denied Edo people this best practice approach to continuous growth having completely neglected all the aforementioned areas that are key to the developmental continuum of the state.

One would have thought that with the receipt of colossal revenues that surpassed those of past administrations, the state would have undergone massive transformation. On the contrary, she remains terribly underdeveloped. Aside the Paris Club refund, the over ₦20 billion bailout fund by the Federal government, the \$75 million World Bank loan for SEEFOR projects, Edo state government has also received a gross sum of ₦681.31 billion as Internally Generated Revenue (IGR- **₦195.57 billion**) and monthly allocation from the Federation Account Allocation Committee (FAAC- **₦485.74 billion**) for the past 6 years according to the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS). Ironically, Edo State emerged one of the top borrowers in the country as at the second quarter of 2023 according to the Debt Management Office (DMO) with a debt growth rate of 63.77%. At the time, her domestic debt profile stood at ₦126.15 billion. Presently, the state has the highest profile in terms of external debt (\$261.15 million) among the South-South states, and third nationally (**National Bureau of Statistics Report, Q2, 2023**) making her highly susceptible to exchange rate volatility. With a debt to GDP ratio of 4.84%, a debt to revenue ratio of 134.18%, a debt service to revenue ratio of 19.85%, and personnel cost to revenue ratio of 28.94%, the state currently ranks 18th on the debt sustainability index. Likewise, her debt per capita amounted to ₦45,801, surpassing the IGR per capita which stood at ₦9,130. These figures are not conjured; they are products of gross mismanagement of our collective patrimony and can be subjected to verification.

When billions of tax payers' money are expended in signing and showcasing Memorandums Of Understanding (MOU) and feasibility studies such as those of the Gelele Seaport, the Ologbo Modular Refinery, and the Benin Industrial Park (which have all ended as mirages), under the pretence of bringing investments to Edo state, a direct consequence is youth unemployment and under-employment. It has been characteristic of this government to abuse state resources, by improperly utilizing or allocating them instead of appropriately or suitably employing them in enhancing job creation through actual investment in critical sectors of the economy. With 8 out of 10 qualified youths unable to find jobs, the new National Bureau of Statistics methodology for calculating unemployment rate showed that Edo State has a high rate of youth unemployment- 49.02%, in 2020. This is contrary to the promise of creating 200,000 jobs. While we commend the government for the completion of the state's civil service secretariat, it is disturbing that the Governor has failed to replace either those he sacked or others who have retired from active service.

Edo state has the potential to attract serious and realizable investments, both domestic and foreign. This is supposed to be the primary purpose of the much talked about “**Alaghodaro**” (which means “**Moving**

Forward in Benin language) summit, which has been hosted yearly with billions of tax payer's money since the coming on board of this administration. Unfortunately, this all-time expensive economic conclave has fallen significantly short of expectations. As private businesses continue to fold-up because of the hostile business climate deliberately created and passionately nurtured by this administration, Edo people now generally refer to **"Alaghodaro"** as **"Alaghiyeke"**, which connotes **"Moving backward"**. In proof, the state was graded among the least performing states, having ranked 33rd on the **"ease of doing business"** according to BudgiT Nigeria in 2022.

Furthermore, it is sad that the Edo State Fertilizer and Chemical Company Auchi and the Cassavita Factory, Uromi, established when I was Secretary to Edo State Government were inoperative through out the period that Governor Obaseki served as the head of Edo state's economic team. It took the second term of this administration's life cycle before its importance to the advancement of Edo's economic fortunes was realized. Not long ago, the new operators of the fertilizer company, **WACOT Limited**, confirmed that they have made over N15 billion from the sale of about 80,000 tonnes of NPK fertilizers in Edo State. The company which has the capacity to serve other parts of the country provides a steady supply of inputs to boost yields and improve food sufficiency while providing jobs to locals in Auchi, Etsako West Local Government Area of the State. For this, we are happy and our administration's economic team will revisit every other abandoned industrial prospects such as Edo pharmaceuticals, Edo Line, and Bendel Brewery among others for the purpose of reactivating them to meet the daunting challenges of youth unemployment. Nonetheless, we thank the President of Believers' Love World Outreach, Pastor Chris Oyakhilome for purchasing the Ewu Feed and Flour Mill now known as Prime Feed and Flour Mill, Ewu and bringing it back to a fully operational state. That this mill has attained a functional state is inconsistent with the claim by the government that all moribund industries are irredeemable. It is a pity that the technocratic Governor who arrogantly boast of his economic prowess have not been able to move our state forward.

As a matter of fact, unless the Edo state government decides to set up industries or create an enabling environment for investors to establish viable industries, the present high rate of youth unemployment in the state will continue unabated. This situation, largely accounts for the prevailing incidences of youth restiveness, which manifests in the high and growing rates of armed robbery, kidnapping, thuggery and cultism. Presently, Edo state is now literally a sanctuary for disgruntled youths who vent their frustration and anger over their social marginalization even when they are law abiding and hardworking citizens.

Most worrisome, irksome, and tiresome is the devastating dilapidation of the road infrastructure in Edo state generally. Despite the government's claim of dedicating 65% of its capital vote to road maintenance, majority of the roads in Benin City are in parlous conditions. In place of a holistic modernization and quite specifically road multiplication, the government cannot even boast of scarce and shoddy road maintenance, talk less of mooted the idea of constructing new ones that would have added to the social capital stock and development opportunities available to our people. Amidst the humongous ecological funds available and the nearly 30 billion naira expended on the Benin Storm Water Project, the state's erosion control master plan, embarked upon by the administration of Comrade Adams Aliu Oshiomhole remains abandoned by this government. This is why year-in, year-out, as erosion ravages most part of the city, the bad roads become unmotorable, deserted project sites are transformed into interim streams and rivers and as anticipated, so many families are rendered homeless in the process. Often than not,

these forsaken projects become either death traps, or hideout for criminals and this situation of helplessness pervades across the three senatorial districts.

As in industrial development and road infrastructure, there are innumerable questions begging for answers in the agricultural sector. What happened to rice production in Edo Central senatorial district, the cocoa produce in Owan and Ovia North-East Local Government Areas and the timber we were once renowned for? The outgoing administration often boasts of an oil palm revolution, but then, this is nothing new. It was under the Lucky Igbiniedion administration that Okomu and Presco oil companies flourished and got enlisted into the Nigerian Stock Exchange (**NSE**). What has happened in reality is that Edo state government has performed abysmally in this sector for many more reasons as adduced beneath.

The over N2B supposedly invested in Sobe farms, in Sobe, Owan West Local government area of Edo State which Governor Obaseki allegedly handed over to SaroAfrica Company is a complete hoax; the 2018 CBN Agricultural Credit Scheme (**CACS**) of N5B, a loan, meant to assist Edo farmers in clearing their farmlands so as to increase their yields remains unaccounted for. With regards to the later, while the government of Edo state claimed to have expended a whooping N2.8B in clearing these lands, Edo farmers continue to await the said lands for cultivation. The names, phone numbers and location of the farmers to whom the balance of N2.2B was shared have remained a mystery. In July 2020, farmers under the auspices of Edo State Concerned Farmers Association protested in Abuja over alleged misappropriation of another N75 billion agricultural loan obtained by Obaseki's administration from the Central Bank of Nigeria (**CBN**) and the World Bank for the Agripreneur Programme in Sobe. The group claimed that since the planting and harvest some three years before, they were yet to receive proceeds from the sale of their produce. Amongst other reliefs, the farmers asked the CBN and EFCC to take urgent steps to ensure that they are paid by the Edo State Government and Saro Agro Sciences Limited. Clearly, these projects and many more were deliberately designed to fail from the beginning in Edo state. In another case of capital flight, they were orchestrated to serve as a drainpipe for siphoning the scarce resources of Edo people into the pockets of government agents, her cronies and surrogates in the guise of Agric vendors from other states. Of innate concern is the fact that these loans are serviced by monthly deductions at source from the Federation account. The situation is appalling and leaves too much to be desired.

Historically, education has always been the main industry and competitive edge of our people. This is why the ill-advised policy of the current State Government to yank it off from its customary pre-eminence in the ranking of developmental priorities offends common sense. Today, the most notable activity in the education sector since the coming on board of this administration has been the closure of institutions that were set up ab initio to improve the agricultural and the educational sectors of the state's economy while the few that are unaffected like the Ambrose Alli University, Ekpoma, remains one of the least funded state-owned universities in the country according to data from the National Universities Commission (**NUC**). Till date, the College of Agriculture, Iguoriakhi, remains closed and with staff sacked. As host communities count their losses, the College of Education in Igueben, the Michael Imodu College of Physical Education, Afuze, the College of Agriculture Technology, Agenebode and many others that met similar fate, bears testimony to the incapacity of this government to initiate the establishment or sustenance of educational institutions. Fortunately, it took the intervention of the Federal Government for the then College of Education, Ekiadolor, which was hitherto owned and shut down by the state

government for over five years to be reactivated and remodeled to the now Federal College of Education (Technical), Ekiadolor.

In its usual manner, the government of Edo introduced some selfish and uneconomical programs and policies in primary and secondary education that have resulted in huge capital flight. The scant in-service retraining for teachers which was intentionally and fraudulently designed to enrich a few who are outside the boundaries of Edo, have not only failed to meet its objectives, but has also been grossly inadequate and lacking the potency to meet up with existing realities. There have been no effort aimed at increasing access to education for vulnerable children and youths, and no recruitment of teachers as replacement for those that have retired. This shortage of teaching personnel has adversely affected the quality and standard of primary and secondary education in the state especially in rural areas where just one or two teachers are found in schools.

Ostensibly, the only meaningful contribution that this government made in the education sector for the past seven years is the yet uncompleted renovation of the Benin Technical College whose budget is about ₦10million per classroom. Even this was done with the Universal Basic Education (UBEC) funds, to which the Federal Government made 60% counterpart contribution that the state government has never acknowledged; an attitude which smacks off deceit. Beyond this, nothing else of note has been accomplished.

As critical as it is, health care delivery was also not spared in the neglect and decay of these past seven years as it accounts for only a paltry 5.57% of the state's total spending. In a cynical move, the Edo Specialist Hospital which was built, equipped and commissioned with Edo tax payers' money by the administration of former Governor Comrade Adams Aliu Oshiomhole was handed over without due process to a private firm, owned by a non-Edo indigene, who now charges exorbitant fees, way beyond what the average Edo person can afford. As a way to ensure that the people have no other available and affordable option, the over 100 years old Central Hospital, built by the colonial masters with 300 beds, and that served a large percentage of the poor and indigent population was callously destroyed. In its shameless defense, the state government mentioned that the famous hospital site was earmarked for the construction of a museum even when the museum at ring road has long been abandoned and begging for attention. The government seem to suggest that the history of the past which museums represent has more significance than a place that caters for the living. Efforts by civil society groups in Edo State to ascertain the true status of the specialist hospital were met with attacks by state sponsored thugs who beat up journalists and members of these civil society organizations during a peaceful protest. The Primary Health Care Centres that the administration inherited are in a decrepit and miserable condition. Where they exist, they lack drugs, and are manned by a few poorly trained, under-paid and unmotivated health personnel. By implication, the objective of providing affordable and quality health care for Edo people have been defeated.

As a result of these and more, Edo State now has some of the worst health care indicators among the southern states. The state's infant (under-5) mortality rate is 81 per 1,000 which exceeds the national average of 70, and the maternal mortality rate of 814 per 100,000 births are some of the highest rates in Southern Nigeria. Health insurance coverage for women stands at 2.10% while total health spending per capital is ₦2,189.65. The HIV/AIDS prevalence of 3.4% in Edo State exceeds the prevailing national average of 2.1% by 1.3%, and this translates to nearly 50,105 more people living with HIV/AIDS, ranking her 4th in

the country according to a Bayesian Predictive Modelling Study on the **“Estimation of HIV prevalence and burden in Nigeria”**. The number of physicians and nurses in Edo State are 0.49 and 1.15 per 10,000-population respectively. With only two surgeons and no anesthetist serving over 4.5 million persons, the state ranks among the lowest on the African continent by the World Health Organization (WHO) standards. These ugly health care statistics are indicative of the steep reduction in access to quality health care by our people courtesy of the near complete abandonment of primary health care by this administration.

Closely related to health are matters that concern environmental sanitation. Edo is at the top of the non-compliant states for its inability to install necessary mechanisms for ensuring and sustaining good environmental health and sanitation which will curb the prevalent outbreaks of acute perennial flooding, air and water borne pollution, alongside their attendant diseases and epidemics. Across the states, drains are blocked by silt, polythene bags and every other kinds of debris; they are hardly desilted or cleaned. Same goes for our streets- they are either littered beyond comprehension with waste- both decomposables (as in food waste and others) and the non-decomposables (plastics and bottles etc) or they are hosts to stagnant waters with their associated disease causing organisms such as the mosquito larvae. Today, malaria is a major public health concern in Edo state. The occurrence rate is 246.9 per 1000 population while its prevalence by microscopy increased to 22.6% in 2021 according to the World Health Organization's report on Malaria in 2022.

Even though the Edo state government seemed to have brought the illicit activities of Community Development Associations (CDA) to check over land grabbing, little did Edo people know that the government was only preparing grounds for it to assume the unholy role. Today, Mr Godwin Obaseki as Edo's governor, is unarguably the most renowned for land grabbing, amongst elected and military governors that have ruled the state from its creation. In 2022, the elders and people of Oke-Oroma community in Ikpoba-Okha Local Government Area of the state dragged the government to the State High Court over the forceful take over of their ancestral land. Despite the court order restraining the government and other parties from further trespassing on, bulldozing or developing the said land, Gov. Godwin Obaseki, in the guise of repossessing lands that belongs to the state government for the construction of a new town, ordered a comprehensive demolition of hundreds of houses worth billions of naira belonging to ordinary Edo people at a time that they are passing through hardship. It is on record, that the said land and the forest reserve was de-acquired by the Lucky Igbinedion administration and handed over to the natives when urban development was approaching the community. Awaiting justice, the community in March 2023, decided to seek redress at the ECOWAS court.

Again, to ease the forceful grabbing of the vast forest reserve estates of Edo for single crop plantation owners, Governor Obaseki reversed the decision taken by the administration of Comrade Adams Oshiomhole in 2015 to revoke 13,750 hectares of the higher biodiversity concentrated lowland of the Okomu and the Owan Forest Reserve of the state, and hand same over to the local communities (**see Edo State of Nigeria Gazette No 16 of 2015, Volume 1, page 48 to 51**). To ensure a smooth sail, through the rubber-stamp state House of Assembly, he initiated and supervised the expunging of the long existing forestry law, which gave the ownership of such farm lands to local communities, and passed the colonial forestry law that has deprived indigents of their land.

In furtherance, the Edo state government has also allocated more of the vast lands of Owan and Lueleha/Ora/Ozalla lowland rainforest reserves to Fayus Nigeria Limited (**about 5,085 hectares**) and several other local companies alleged to be fronts to the aforementioned multinational company. Likewise, the adjoining forest reserve of Ekiadolor, in Ovia North East Local Government Area, as well as those in Owan West, Owan East, Esan West, Etsako East, Uhunmwode, Orhiomwon and Ikpoba Okha and others, spanning over 400 local communities have been ceded to the same SaroAfrica and already bulldozed for mono-cropping. This is in total defiance to the fact that the company has a pending petition at the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission (**EFCC**) over the failed Sobe farm project.

It is on record that even the initial N67 billion CBN loan that was allocated for the development and expansion of oil palm plantations for the aforementioned companies and local farmers has been diverted. The promise made by the plantation owners that the locals will benefit from their huge investments through employment and more, have been jettisoned. In a few cases where jobs are available, the locals continue to cry over abysmal wages. Obviously, local farmers have been schemed out by the government and are left to scramble for leftover lands with herdsmen. This is most painful, unfair, and unfortunate! As the host communities continue to gnash their teeth amidst several unproductive street protests aimed at seeking redress, the plantation owners are smiling to the bank and repatriating their profits. This unfavourable and poorly thought out agricultural policy of Governor Godwin Obaseki will in the long run, displaced aboriginal land owners from their communities of birth thereby shutting them out of their means of livelihood. Such will cause an unprecedented migration to city centers which will lead to urban congestion.

Some may have wondered why the Benin Enterprise Park project suddenly came to a halt. In this particular case, over 997 hectare of land was released to Amaya Real Estate Holdings Limited, a UK offshore company that was registered in April 2019, just three months after the registration of the Park. Definitely, Amaya was designed to be the major investor in Benin Enterprise Park in Agbonmoba Community, Km 22, Benin Sapele Road, Edo State. Edo people are unaware that the Benin Enterprise Park Limited is listed at the Corporate Affairs Commission as a **“Private Company Limited by Shares”** entirely; yet, the state government ceded such vast expanse of land to it. By sheer providence, the project has since been abandoned because of an ongoing litigation between it and the Benin Owina River Basin Development Authority, the alleged owners of the property.

Beyond the aforesaid examples, Governor Obaseki has brashly handed over thousands of hectares of farmlands and forest reserve to expatriate farmers without commensurate benefits to the state as well as the host communities and their indigenous people and/or inhabitants. This action if not checked will create in the nearest future the kind of war between **“white farmers”** and the **“aborigines”** in South Africa today.

In addition to the already stated implications of forest land grabbing and its dastardly effects on environmental preservation is grave. According to the Midwest Herald in a publication on 19th November, 2023, by Tony Erha, a journalist and environmental conservationist, with additional files from Moses Abehe- **“of all the agents that are implicated in deforestation, losses to biodiversity, habitat and livelihood, the indiscriminate allocation of vast forest reserved lands, belonging to local communities, to big time plantations companies, for the erection of monocrop plantations, most of which are foreign multinationals and their local front companies, is the highest driver”**. They added that- **“amongst the 36**

states of the country, the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) and the Forestry Global Watch (FGW) had classified Edo state as the highest driver of deforestation and habitat losses in the country". Another study conducted by Nigeria Deforestation Rates and Statistics listed Edo, Ondo, Cross River, Taraba, and Ogun States as the worst affected states, with Edo leading the pack of environmental offenders. Global Forest Watch, an open-source web application that monitors global forest in near real-time, reported that from 2001 to 2022, Edo lost 309Kha of tree cover, equivalent to a 30% decrease in tree cover and 181 Mt of CO₂ emissions. In 2021, Edo state had the most tree cover loss (18,200 hectares) in Nigeria. Yet, acute deforestation and habitat losses are the principal causes of climate change.

Edo state is a host to several varieties of wildlife. The Okomu National Park located in Ovia South West local government area has provided shelter for thousands of animal species over the years. Regrettably, the park, was heinously poached and vandalized while illegal logging was also visited on it under the watch of this administration. But for the African Nature Investors (ANI), which came to the rescue of the premier global conservation terrain, it would have been completely destroyed. As well, the Benin Ogba Zoo and Nature Park (BENZOPA), Benin City, was not spared. Till date, many land grabbers and poachers who are powerful in this government are pressing for the relocation of the centre from its current place so that they can grab the land and cause the zoo to loose its ancient heritage and splendor.

Disturbingly, the actions and in-actions of the governor and his government towards the traditional institutions in Edo state have been abominable. This highly revered institutions do not only represent our culture and custom, they are equally vital to the enthronement and actualization of any sustainable social/economic development plan. Without proper consultation and collaboration with them, no government, be it democratically elected or otherwise can succeed. Aside the state government, the pronouncement by the federal government that the repatriated artifacts should be in the custody of the rightful owner, the Oba of Benin was applauded by every well-meaning Edolite. The governor, in an attempt to express his dissatisfaction and disdain, vehemently refused to dialogue or seek the partnership and blessing of His Royal Majesty, before embarking on the construction of a new museum. Governor Godwin Obaseki has continued to stalk the Omo N'Oba over the custody of these artifacts in whose absence one begins to wonder the purpose for the continued construction of the new museum which is already gulping billions of naira. This willful and conspicuous disrespect and disregard of the PDP led government for our Royal Father, the Oba of Benin and the traditional institutions generally has since reached its zenith. If this is the "**Alaghodaro**" that the governor is advocating, then, God forbid!

The issue of insecurity in Edo state has become of immense concern to all citizens, most of whom continue to wonder how the state arrived at such a terrible situation where no one is safe: and worse still, rather than abate, the problem is escalating and out of control. Edo state is plagued by cyber crimes, armed robbery, kidnapping, domestic crimes, consistent cult related killings, and so on. Today, many communities such as Odighi, Odiguetue, and Okokhuo, in Ovia North-East and Iguelaba and Oben in Orhionmwon local government areas and lots more have been ravaged and deserted. In the process, lives and livelihood have been lost due to herder-farmer clashes. Even though the governor has since set up a state vigilante's network to assist the police, civil defense and other security outfit in combating crime, members of the network are improperly recruited, grossly inexperienced, untrained, unpaid and many of them are in possession of weapons whose sources are questionable. Incessantly too, they have complained of lack of logistic funding. Unmoved and unbothered, Governor Obaseki has continued to cultivate and nurture the habit of fanning the embers of divisive politics. His determination to physically

assault any fellow party faithful who aspires to run for governor or is not willing to support his preferred candidate has created a tense and volatile environment.

What to do?

This dangerous trend can only be reversed when a new leadership that can accommodate and tolerate the views of others, and that is committed to peaceful engagement is elected to serve you. With such competent and purposeful leadership comes a strategic plan of action that will help to cultivate the right collaborations, formulate the appropriate policies, create the necessary frameworks and design programs to empower our youths, women and children while also implementing other people-oriented projects even with limited resources. This is the kind of change that we desire; one that struggles for true democracy and whose agenda seeks to locate the people at its epicenter. In changing from the old ways of doing things, we can end the sufferings of our people and improve the business environment for genuine local and foreign direct investments.

Dear compatriots, we are presently on the wrong path and we definitely and urgently need a new direction. Now is the time to fight for freedom from political tyranny, reckless misuse of our scarce communal resources, rapid and unsustainable accumulation of domestic and external debts as a burden for generations unborn. Let us rise up for the emancipation of our people.

In line with established global best practices, we have decided to roll out a simplified model of a long-term people-centric economic growth and empowerment plan. We shall use the “**SIMPLE Agenda**” to bring economic and social justice to all, irrespective of their political, religious or ethnic inclinations. This agenda will halt and reverse the dwindling fortunes of our youths, women, and pensioners. I am passionate and enthusiastic about us achieving this because Edo is my home; I was born here and have lived here ever since.

Who is Pastor Osagie Ize-Iyamu?

I am a direct descendant of Chief Odia, the Iyase N’Ohenmwun to Oba Osemwende who hailed from Iguododo in Orhionmwon Local Government Area. He was known in his days as the most loyal and reliable Iyase of Benin Kingdom (Prime Minister). Chief Iyamu, my great grandfather, who was the Inneh of Benin, built the first storey building (Egedege Nokaro) in Midwest Region in 1906. My father, Chief Robert Osayande Ize-Iyamu, his grandson, who was the Esogban of Benin Kingdom, donated one of his houses at No. 32 Erie Street, Benin City to be used as the secretariat of the Movement for the Creation of Edo State in 1984. This movement was chaired by His Royal Majesty, the Oba of Benin, Oba Erediauwa II. I attended Ebenezer Primary School, Benin City after which I proceeded to Edo College, also in Benin for my secondary education. Subsequently, I gained admission into the prestigious University of Benin and obtained a bachelor’s degree in Law in 1986. Upon graduation, I went to the Nigerian Law School, Lagos and was called to the Nigerian Bar in 1987. I am a Pastor, Farmer and Businessman. I am happily married to Prof. Mrs. Idia Nibokun Ize-Iyamu and we are blessed with four children.

I have been privileged to serve our beloved state in various capacities. Between 1988 and 1989, I was Special Assistant to the Chairman of the old Oredo Local Government Council which consist of the

present Oredo, Egor and Ikpoba Okha local government areas. From 1999 to 2003, I was appointed Chief of Staff to the Governor of Edo state and in 2003 to 2007, I was Secretary to the State Government. These positions, which I held creditably and without blemish, have given me a unique insight into the workings of government.

I am aware of the importance of electing an experienced and competent state Chief Executive who would stay focused on the discharge of his duties. That is why, I, Pastor Dr. Osagie Ize-Iyamu Esq., seek your mandate to contest for the office of the Governor of Edo State in 2024. I am of the strong conviction that our “*Better Tomorrow*”, the future upon which we rest our hope, is now. The road ahead will be long, but with God’s grace upon us, we shall keep our eyes fixed on that horizon no matter the challenges that may confront us. I encourage you, join your hands with mine on the arc of history and let’s bend it toward the hope of a “*Greater Tomorrow*”. I am willing, able and ready!

Toward Effective Resource Mobilization

Before undertaking a detailed description of how the **SIMPLE Agenda** will be implemented, we will like to address the relevant question of resource mobilization and fund raising. In these days of severe national economic downturn, a relevant question is:

Where would an emerging administration find the resources to implement a new and progressive agenda for up-lifting Edolites from a condition of want and poverty to one of prosperity and life more abundant?

For me, those who complain that resources are not enough should understand that there will never be a time that resources would be enough. I have the experience to attract FDIs and other multilateral agencies such as the World Bank, International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), Department for International Development (DFID), Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA), MacArthur Foundation and many others to Edo state. Many of them are already in this country working in some places. IFAD for example has been in some parts of the Niger Delta doing a lot in agriculture. We will localize them and advance their goals for the good of our people and they will be happy to collaborate with us.

Some of the new steps that we would take to mobilize the needed resources (human, financial and technological) for governing the state includes the following:

- The establishment of an **Economic Management Team (EMT)** that includes the best minds in the industry – and a team leader that has the credentials to perform in a holistic and broad based manner, not one that will promote extortive taxation as the only means of revenue derivation.
- Within 6 months of our coming into office, we will convene an international EDO Development Summit that will sell the EDO brand to investors both at home and abroad. We will reach out to them to support our efforts to re-build a new and prosperous Edo State.
- In the contemporary society, economic growth alone does not guarantee reduction in poverty, but equitable income distribution is what matters. The state has the potential to survive on tax revenue if the right parameters are set out for them. Therefore, we will deviate from the practice of virtually depending on the Federal Government statutory allocation for our programs.
- Our economic model will be based on diversification – to harness the immense economic potentials that abound in the state. These include agriculture, solid minerals, oil and gas, cultural products and tourism.

- We will invest in mechanized agriculture, provide agricultural extension services and promote agro-based industries that will help add value to agricultural produce and at the same time engage a sizable percentage of our people in gainful employment.
- Taxation will remain a veritable part of revenue generation in our government. However, our administration's policy on taxation will be pursued alongside a wealth creation policy that will bring about the economic empowerment of our people so as to promote happiness among the greater majority.
- We will plug financial leakages, improve efficiency in public expenditure and build a robust and sustainable financial base for the state.
- For the first time in the annals of public administration in Edo State, our government will institutionalize a robust Monitoring and Evaluation (**M&E**) mechanism to track public programs and project implementation in the state.
- We will establish a team of experts that will link Edo State to the opportunities created by the new donor funding under the Sustainable Development Goals that was recently pronounced for global development from 2015-2030 by the United Nations. We will reach out to donor organizations such as the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, Ford Foundation, United Nations Development Fund, McArthur Foundation, World Health Organization, and bilateral/multilaterals such as USAID, DFID, JICA and NORAD.

"The purpose of government is the pursuance of happiness for the greater majority of the people. The Government of Edo State under my leadership will strive to meet this purpose at all times. We will serve the needs of the good people of Edo State efficiently, effectively and fairly through good governance that is geared towards solving social problems".

Our Agenda is SIMPLE; "Life is really simple, but we insist on making it complicated" - Confucius.

The **SIMPLE Agenda** is an acronym for:

- S** - Security and Social Welfare
- I** - Infrastructural Development/Urban Renewal
- M** - Manpower Development and Training
- P** - Public Private Partnership (PPP)
- L** - Leadership By Example
- E** - Employment Creation and Social Empowerment Scheme

S: SECURITY AND SOCIAL WELFARE

1) Security

Although the potentials of the state are huge in terms of our ability to attract tourists, investments and quality jobs. However, the current security situation in the state makes the realization of these deliverables unrealistic and unattainable. Many of those in the diaspora have demonstrated their willingness to come home and invest their skills and material resources for the state's development, given proper incentives. Unfortunately, the current level of insecurity in the state makes the actualization of such initiatives a pipe dream.

We will provide an enabling environment for our people so that they can channel investments back to our state.

- A global best practice approach to security delivery, involving all stakeholders in our communities and the use of well-trained and motivated personnel will be adopted to make Edolites sleep with their two eyes closed once again.
- Edo State under our charge will build a new security architecture.
- This is the 21st century, so we must think and act accordingly. In this regard, the creation of an emergency system like 911 will be uppermost in our plans to address insecurity in the state.
- Adequate materials and institutional support for the Police and other security agencies in the state will be provided.
- **Edo State Security Trust Fund** which will be established as a special purpose vehicle to mobilize funding for the security agencies on a sustainable basis.
- Community policing Program involving neighborhood watch and vigilante groups will be established in rural and urban areas.
- We will partner with the traditional rulers, village heads, school authorities and religious organizations in our quest to find a pragmatic and lasting solution to kidnapping and frequent brawls at public places.
- Continue efforts to keep students, teachers, and personnel safe on campus.
- We shall design and implement a month-by-month security funding mechanism for traditional security by funding and maintaining a traditional security apparatus to be administered by the traditional institutions.

2) Social Welfare

- Our administration will develop a comprehensive plan to make social welfare programs work for our people. Every resident of Edo State will be allotted a personalized life time Social Security Number (SSN).
- Social welfare offices will be set up in the three senatorial districts. They will be empowered by law to adjudicate on matrimonial problems and help resolve them through family counseling and mediating services.
- We are all living witnesses to the deplorable irregularity that attends the payment of pensioners in the state. All these will become a thing of the past once we assume office.
- Appropriate legislation and initiatives that will protect the vulnerable and disabled persons in our state from discrimination and exploitation will be enacted.

- An Edo State Employment Bureau (ESEB) will be established. This bureau will be responsible for identifying the unemployed in the state and capturing them in a database that would include their qualifications.
- Policies that will protect widows and children of the deceased from harassment and intimidation will be initiated and enforced. Under such policies, provision will be made to ensure that widows and children have easier access to the estate, pension and other assets or benefits of the deceased.
- Child labor and abuse will be discouraged and we shall stimulate proper enlightenment on the provisions of the child protection law and ensure its enforcement.

I: INFRASTRUCTURAL DEVELOPMENT & URBAN RENEWAL

The main objective of the infrastructural development and urban renewal programme will be to bequeath to the state, physical structures and facilities that will promote decent living standards for our people. Our integrated approach to development will be stepped-up in every area from modern Information Technology infrastructure to new ways of building public works systems. This would be accompanied with cost and resource effectiveness to eliminate wastage, promote skills development and bequeath a state-of-the-art infrastructure that future generations will utilize and be proud of.

1) Roads and Drains

Our goal is to have all major roads and streets within Benin City as well as those in every local government headquarter asphalted. In most cases, these roads will be accompanied with walkways, drains and street lights, in an unprecedented urban renewal scheme that will be embarked upon.

- Emphasis will be placed on the reconstruction and rehabilitation of existing road networks with a view to bringing the various communities back to life and improving environmental sanitation, public health and security of lives and properties.
- Strategic roads, linking communities with major roads and serving as alternative routes will be identified and constructed.
- All on-going projects will be completed to ensure value for taxpayers' money.
- The rehabilitation of roads, particularly in the Local Government Councils shall be a policy directive to the Local Government Council Chairmen and this will be implemented in conjunction with the State Government.
- Communities shall be encouraged to embark on self-help projects to which the LGAs and the state government shall contribute meaningfully.
- In specific terms, adequate funding will be extended to roads and drains within the local government areas. We will deploy both primary and secondary drains that will properly channel floodwaters.
- We shall review the Benin Storm Water Project and ensure it is completed within a reasonable period to address the problem of perennial flooding in the state capital.

- The erosion reclamation projects and sites in the state will be diligently tackled to their completion stage and we shall honour all outstanding obligations to the World Bank and other relevant agencies.
- As part of our deliberate plan to create new towns and settlements around Benin City, a second bridge to link Upper St. Saviour and Ikpoba Hill will be constructed.
- We will extend the Airport Road construction to continue across the bridge to Evbuodia-Utagba Village to join Ekenwan Barrack road by Ojemai farms.
- Construction of Uteh-Ekiuwa road
- Construction of UNIBEN-Uteh road
- Completion of the Ekehuan-GeleGele port road
- Construction of the Adolor-Uwelu road
- Reconstruction of the Ogida market-Uwelu-Egor road
- Construction of the Evbotubu-Uwelu-Adolor-Ugbowo road (under the power line)
- Construction/rehabilitation of the Obadan-Isi-Ugonoba road
- Construction/rehabilitation of the Iruokpen-Orhua-Ehor-Oke road
- Construction/rehabilitation of the Ehor-Ukpogo-Ugiamen-Ekpoma road
- Traversing Auchi (Polytechnic gate) in South Ibie to Ekperi, Agenebode, Anegbete, Ugboha and Uromi will be a new experience for motorists. These roads will open up several communities and will boost socio-economic integration between Edo North and Edo Central Senatorial districts.
- We shall construct the Iruokpen-Sabo-Uzala-Afuze-Uhomore road
- We shall construct the Afuze-Era road
- Rehabilitation of the Uromi-Agbor road
- Construction of a road linking Osomegbe and Udochi
- In partnership with the federal government, we shall construct of a bridge across river Niger through Agenebode
- We shall construct some flyovers/overhead bridges in strategic locations across the state to decongest and ease traffic flow.
- Construction of a light rail for passengers side by side a cargo train stretching from benin/gelegele to Ekpoma and Okpella then to join the national lines such as that in Agbor
- A major plank of our infrastructural development programme is to use it for job creation. Therefore, we will contact some reputable construction firms to station their plant and machinery in each of the three Senatorial Districts for ease of mobilization and deployment As part of the contractual agreement, such contractors must draw their labor (skilled and unskilled) from the host communities as a direct approach to employment generation.
- Edo State Road Maintenance Agency with full complements of earth moving equipment will be established.

2) Electrification

Edo state is endowed with abundant energy resources both conventional and renewable which can potentially provide sufficient capacity to meet the ambitions of both urban and

rural citizens. Paradoxically, Edo state has one of the lowest electricity per capita ratio in the country and this deficit provides an opportunity for investment in renewable energy.

- The aim of the “**SIMPLE Agenda**” is to reduce rural to urban migration. Therefore, the deregulation of electricity supply and maintenance notwithstanding, we shall give priority to rural electrification through the provision of transformers, feeder pillars, poles and other equipment to bring electricity to the doorsteps of rural dwellers while enhancing local economic and social activities.
- Specifically, all towns, villages, and communities across the state will be connected to the national grid in a sustainable manner.
- We would be willing to partner with investors in power generation in order to improve power supply in our state.
- We shall take advantage of the Embedded Power Generation option, which allows us to generate up to 10megawatts of electricity and have multiple plants to power industries in cluster areas.
- We shall invest in plants that will generate energy from household and other decomposable waste. This will not only ensure steady power to homes, it will also help to keep the state cleaner while the by-product (ash) can be employed in road maintenance.
- We would develop strategic partnerships with local, national and international investors to pioneer alternative renewable energy generation including solar and wind energy.
- These regeneration programs we expect would create over **2,000** direct jobs in electricity dependent industries and would assist in creating over **1,000** new businesses in rural areas.
- We shall encourage the replacement of regular light bulbs with compact florescent light (CFL) bulbs so as to reduce the emission of greenhouse gases.
- Reduce global warming by encouraging residents to turn off lights when not in use.

3) Water Supply

- Our government will reform and invest in Edo State Urban Water Board to boost the provision of potable drinking water across the state.
- We will de-emphasize the present over-reliance on borehole water. To this end, we shall embark on the construction of public water works in selected community clusters across the state, and vigorously embark on the following plans:
 - ✓ Resuscitation, expansion and modernization of all existing Water Schemes, such as Ikpoba River Dam, Ugbialo Water Works, Ojirami Dam, Jattu/Uzaire dam, Ela water works and others across the state.
 - ✓ We shall employ experts and professionals to advise government on the best hygienic conditions for drilling borehole water for domestic use and irrigation.
 - ✓ We shall also decisively pursue international funding for major water projects in our determination to revamp the public water works department.
 - ✓ The Water problem in most parts of Edo Central will be given top priority and will be effectively addressed and solved.

- ✓ These modernization policies and programs are expected to help generate at least 10,000 new construction jobs and safeguard over 3,000 jobs over a four-year period.

4) Healthcare

“A Comprehensive Healthcare Policy” will be formulated and implemented to replace the current healthcare system of Edo State that is in shambles. We shall harmonize the Federal, State and Local Government health care plans and take a cue from the **National Strategic Health Development Plan (NSHDP) II, 2018–2022**.

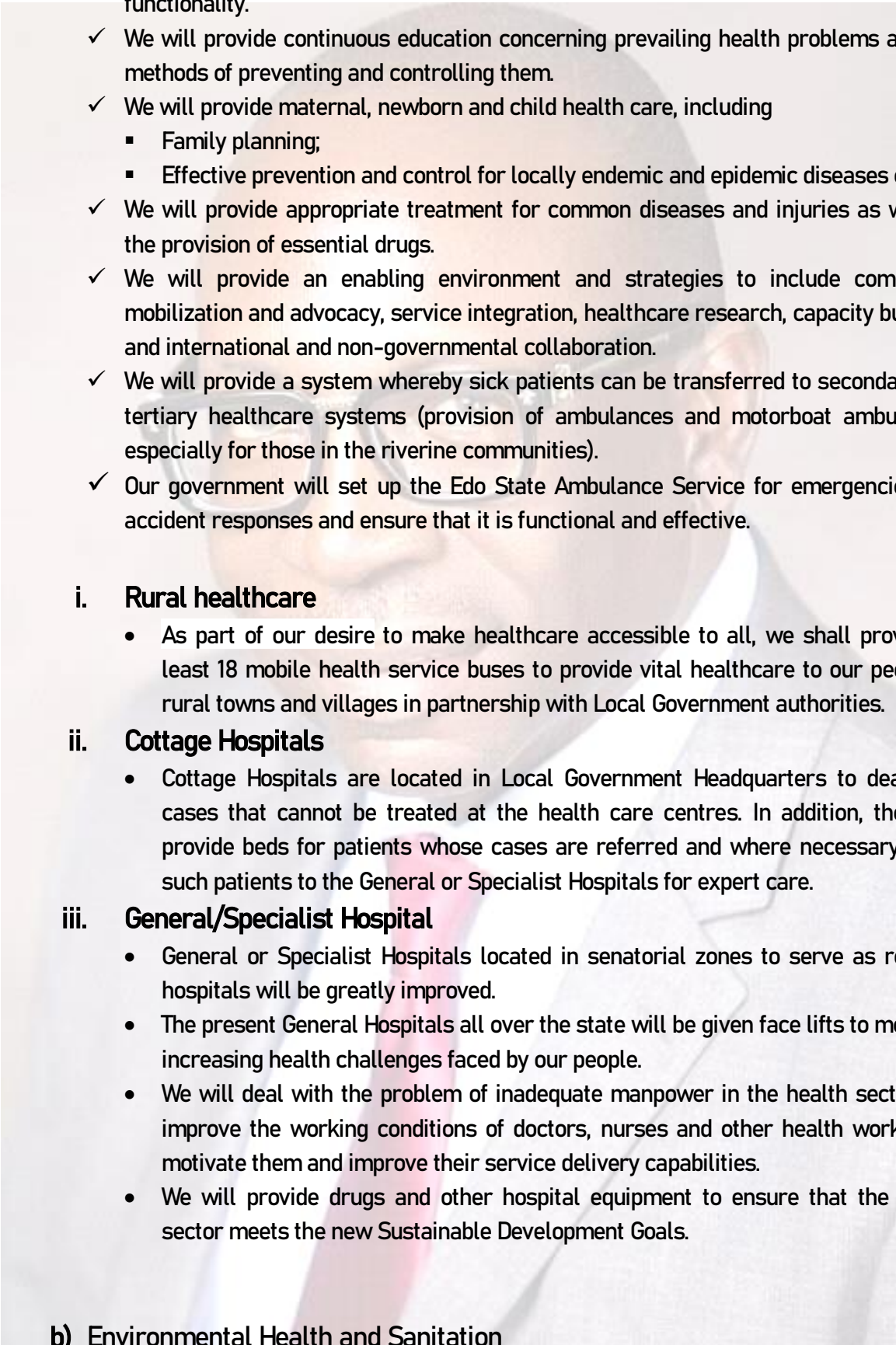
We are glad to observe that the current state government has implemented this plan of ours (*though without credit to us*) with the resultant effect that Edo state was one of the first 6 states to benefit from the N55billion Basic Healthcare Provision Fund.

Regardless, to ensure that the overall goal is met, my administration will establish the “**Simple Strategic Health Development Plan**”. The major objectives of this plan are listed below:

- To set targets for intervention to reduce the prevalence of communicable and non-communicable diseases as well as the prevalence of child and maternal morbidity and mortality.
- To increase life expectancy through an integrated, reformed, restructured and functional health care system.
- To provide the personnel, manpower and institutions that will assist our people by ensuring access to good healthcare delivery.
- To ensure that the good effect of all these services are felt by all, irrespective of their location and socio-economic status.
- To set up a functional disease control agency for surveillance, monitoring and evaluation of diseases such as HIV and AIDS, tuberculosis and leprosy amongst others. This agency will be called the **Edo State Centre for Disease Control**.
- To encourage public/private partnership by promoting private sector participation, standardization and compliance.
- To establish appropriate regulatory institutions to set standards, enforce and monitor compliance.
- To ensure that the state’s “**Simple Strategic Health Development Plan**” and general health services are delivered through the aforementioned channels, the following will be reorganized or constructed:

a) Primary Health Care (PHC)

Primary/Rural Health Centers are situated in rural communities. They are poorly staffed, managed and therefore underutilized. The implementation of **PHC** will be carried out through services at the various primary health centers as well as home visits. To achieve this:

- 
- ✓ We shall establish Primary Health Care Centres in the 192 wards of the state. They will be equipped, adequately staffed with qualified personnel in order to ensure their functionality.
 - ✓ We will provide continuous education concerning prevailing health problems and the methods of preventing and controlling them.
 - ✓ We will provide maternal, newborn and child health care, including
 - Family planning;
 - Effective prevention and control for locally endemic and epidemic diseases e.t.c.
 - ✓ We will provide appropriate treatment for common diseases and injuries as well as the provision of essential drugs.
 - ✓ We will provide an enabling environment and strategies to include community mobilization and advocacy, service integration, healthcare research, capacity building, and international and non-governmental collaboration.
 - ✓ We will provide a system whereby sick patients can be transferred to secondary and tertiary healthcare systems (provision of ambulances and motorboat ambulances especially for those in the riverine communities).
 - ✓ Our government will set up the Edo State Ambulance Service for emergencies and accident responses and ensure that it is functional and effective.

i. Rural healthcare

- As part of our desire to make healthcare accessible to all, we shall provide at least 18 mobile health service buses to provide vital healthcare to our people in rural towns and villages in partnership with Local Government authorities.

ii. Cottage Hospitals

- Cottage Hospitals are located in Local Government Headquarters to deal with cases that cannot be treated at the health care centres. In addition, they will provide beds for patients whose cases are referred and where necessary, refer such patients to the General or Specialist Hospitals for expert care.

iii. General/Specialist Hospital

- General or Specialist Hospitals located in senatorial zones to serve as referral hospitals will be greatly improved.
- The present General Hospitals all over the state will be given face lifts to meet the increasing health challenges faced by our people.
- We will deal with the problem of inadequate manpower in the health sector and improve the working conditions of doctors, nurses and other health workers to motivate them and improve their service delivery capabilities.
- We will provide drugs and other hospital equipment to ensure that the health sector meets the new Sustainable Development Goals.

b) Environmental Health and Sanitation

Edo state presently has less than 10% forest cover which is some way off the United Nations recommendation of at least 25%.

- We will leverage on the opportunity made available by the United Nations and the World Bank to gain enough carbon credit through carbon sequestration and planting of more trees. This will not only ensure a healthier environment, but would also bestow additional source of revenue for the state.
- We shall enact a comprehensive environmental management policy and ensure strict compliance.
- We will see to it that every person in Edo State is encouraged to plant at least 5 trees a year, which comes to over 10 million trees annually.
- Furthermore, we will ensure that our waste management is handled in a more professional and efficient manner by emphasizing **re-cycling and re-use**.
- Edo State government presently has three (3) functional compactor trucks. This is grossly inadequate even for the state capital. More trucks will be procured and reputable waste managers engaged to keep the state clean.
- A sustainable and scientific waste management system, which would include the use of engineering dump site, that prevents the pollution of underground water shall be employed.
- We shall also partner with or create an enabling environment for various types of recycling plants to be established.

c) Fire service

We are seriously concerned about the response of the Edo State Fire Service to critical fire incidences, particularly within our major cities. The Uwelu Spare Parts market, Oliha market, Santana market, Osa market, and the Urhokpota fire disasters all within 8 months have exposed the terrible state of our fire service and the government's disdain for the common man hinged on her failure to respond and prepare for future incidences. Therefore, we will:

- Modernize, scale up and enhance the capacity of Edo State Fire Service to respond timely and efficiently to critical fire incidents within 30 minutes in our cities.
- Every major market in the state will be reformed to accommodate a fire service unit. These units will serve as a branch of the state fire service.
- We will set up dedicated water reservoirs in some areas of the state for the refill of water tanks for fire service trucks.
- These policies would help to create over **3,000** additional new jobs and safeguard 5,000 existing jobs in the sector.

d) Housing

The **"SIMPLE"** Agenda will encourage the Public-Private-Partnership initiative in the provision of decent housing units for people in the state.

- Government will supply quality housing through a policy for social housing for the poor and the vulnerable, and develop affordable houses for workers in the state.

- Access to affordable mortgages at single-digit interest rates will be pursued.
- We shall create new Government Reservation Areas (G.R.A) by allocating lands, providing infrastructure (including road networks) and inviting reputable developers to take over such areas at reasonable cost to government and the affected communities.
- These policies would lead to the creation of additional **10,000** new construction related jobs in the economy.
- We shall ensure the realization and development of Satellite Towns and sundry enterprises
- We shall ensure the sanctity of the prevailing land administration processes and procedures and collaborate with traditional rulers in the state to ensure a transparent and fair land allocation system.

M: MANPOWER DEVELOPMENT AND TRAINING

“The most valuable of all capital is that invested in human beings” – Alfred Marshall, Principles of Economics

Manpower development is the most critical aspect of the **SIMPLE** agenda. This is what many countries have realized and have leveraged to attain greatness. The greatest resource any state has is its people. As such, deliberate efforts must be made in developing their capacities.

1) Education

The programme on education under our stewardship will ensure that no Edo child is left behind. Edo State Government under our leadership will provide free and compulsory education from primary school to junior secondary school. The Edo State education programme will be driven by a determination to train Edo people to be skilled and competitive both nationally and globally through the adoption of the use of modern pedagogical methods including ICT and multi-media platforms.

Our education policy will reflect the following objectives:

- To train our youths in science, engineering, finance, commerce, entrepreneurship, management information and communication technology that will lead the state's drive for prosperity and economic development;
- To make every citizen a literate that is able to communicate in our lingua franca as well as in their mother tongue.
- To go beyond the cosmetic painting of classroom blocks and ensure adequate provision of chairs and tables and relevant learning materials in both primary and secondary schools. We will encourage the development of sports and libraries.
- To motivate teachers through proper remuneration, prompt payment of salaries and emoluments and continued training and re-training.
- To vigorously pursue the re-introduction of boarding facilities in public secondary schools across the state, as this will inculcate leadership qualities in our youths.

- To encourage the interest of students in science and technology and reward outstanding students with full scholarship.
- To ensure the availability of science laboratories in all Senior Secondary Schools and Art and Crafts workshops in Junior Secondary Schools.
- To support teachers in their quest to up-grade themselves to ensure high standards in the education sector.
- To emphasize technical and vocational training so as to improve on the skills and entrepreneurial development of school leavers. Appropriate incentives will be offered to attract students to technical and vocational training in a bid to discourage the over-dependence on tertiary education.
- To re-activate and provide contemporary facilities, equipment and teaching aids to all existing Technical Schools in the state. We will construct modern toilet facilities in or schools.
- Improve on the technical training centres; integrated with skill acquisition, cottage agro-processing and other related small-scale production outfits in each of the senatorial districts for the training of the relevant technical and skilled manpower, to drive all aspects of our economic policies.
- To make ICT and entrepreneurship compulsory components of our policy at all levels of our educational system.
- To provide all government secondary schools with computer laboratories.
- From JSS 1, every child would be exposed to skill acquisition as part of the school system. They would pick 4 different skills from a wide range of skills that may include Carpentry, Catering, Fashion design, Painting as well as Digital skills, Music, Healthcare, Tiling, etc. From SSI, they would then be required to pick only one and specialize.
- To create an education and business partnership framework to give students the opportunity to develop the skills and qualities needed for work. In their last year of SS3, these students will undergo a compulsory four weeks work experience placement.
- By the time the child is graduating from SS3, he/she would have a DIPLOMA in one skill set and a WAEC certificate on the other hand. Such a child would be ready for a future of productivity. The DIPLOMA would be the collateral to obtaining a small business loan to get started in life as a professional and to be a viable human being- able to fend for themselves even if they choose not to go on to a university.
- To raising education standards and achievements in schools through a rigorous quality inspection, monitoring and support regime.
- To address teacher shortages by removing barriers to professional entry and increasing pay.
- These policies would enable the creation of **10,000** sustainable new jobs in the economy

1) Higher and Professional Education

The basic objective of higher and professional education is to improve the capability of young people to identify, formulate and handle scientifically complex problems as well as to critically evaluate information and formulate possible solutions. It also provides leadership and management manpower for the growth and development of the country. Therefore, we shall ensure total overhaul of the existing state tertiary institutions, increase their subvention, improve their personnel and upgrade their infrastructure and facilities.

2) Bursary

We support the idea of giving financial assistance to all our students. Therefore, we shall embark on a comprehensive census of Edo undergraduates in all higher institutions across the country with a view to determining a reasonable, realistic and sustainable annual bursary award to them to promote their educational attainment.

- Our government will run an inclusive educational system and prioritize the provision of tailored education and learning to people with special needs, physical and mental challenges, in order to ensure equality of access and opportunities in life for all regardless of their circumstance.
- **In-Service Training**
Our government will invest in ICT skills training and capacity up-skilling of all government staff to the International Computer Driving License Standards (ICDLs). Our government would actively encourage private sector businesses and industries to likewise invest in up-skilling their staff ICT skills and capacity, which will enable them to maximize accrued advantages in this digital age.
- Our government will encourage applied industrial development and cutting edge technology research. We will encourage industries to build partnerships with our tertiary institutions.

3) Youth Development and Sports

Edo State had a history of sporting glory. The **“SIMPLE”** Agenda will treat youth, sports, recreation and cultural activities as a business model for job and wealth creation. Edo State must be made to regain her premier position in sports in the country. Special funding will be allocated to improve facilities, hire coaches and motivate sports men and women to attain national and international excellence in sports. Some of the specific activities that we would implement for sports development include the following:

- Young people will be encouraged to create businesses in youth development, sports, recreation, and cultural activities. In collaboration with donor agencies, NGOs, corporate bodies, and financial institutions, government will create platforms where young people can access financial assistance for such businesses across the 18 Local Government Areas of the state.
- The government will re-introduce school sports in all public and private primary and secondary schools in the state. This will enable us identify young talents for national competitions in furtherance of the restoration of the state's lost glory in sporting activities.
- Insurance Football Club and other sports clubs and associations will be given special consideration and government will partner with reputable stakeholders to sponsor and promote these clubs.
- In partnership with the private sector, we will re-introduce the Ogbe Hard-Court Tennis Championship as an annual event to boost Sports Tourism.

- To reclaim our leading role in boxing, we shall renovate and re-equip the boxing gymnasiums located in the State.
- We shall collaborate with reputable sports marketing companies to establish sports academies in the state, as this is capable of gainfully engaging many of our youths.
- We shall resuscitate, refurbish and expand the games village in Afuze.
- Our government will promote mainstream equality in sports including encouraging gender parity and disabled equality in participation across a range of sports.

P: PUBLIC PRIVATE PARTNERSHIP (PPP)

Edo State Government under our leadership will embark on wealth creation for the citizens of the state through the uncommon embrace of the public private partnership paradigm to bring about economic prosperity in various sectors of the state's economy.

(1) Industrialization

A strong and prosperous Edo State will depend on a vibrant and growing manufacturing sector that can create competitive advantages in the midst of rapid technological change and globalization of markets, production and innovation. Manufacturing is an antidote for unemployment, a creator of wealth and a harbinger of sustainable development.

The primary objective of the industrialization program of government will be to accelerate the pace of industrial development in the state by leveraging private financing through Public-Private-Partnership. In doing this, the focus will be:

- To re-examine the state existing public and private industries with a view to resuscitating their activities, ensuring profitable operations and increasing employment opportunities.
- Industrial parks, akin to the present Technology Incubation Centers (TIC) will be established in each of the senatorial districts.
- Establish an Export Processing Zone as an industrial and commercial hub
- Mentor the Local Government to establish an Industrial Cluster in their jurisdiction
- To stimulate the growth and development of a culture of industrial production and entrepreneurship in the state.
- To establish a refinery in Ikpoba-Okha because of the oil fields in that locality and its proximity to Koko Port. We also intend through the same PPP to establish a gas plant at Oben in Orhiomwon local government area because of the abundant gas in that area.
- To sponsor an executive bill to create Edo State Investment Promotion Commission (ESIPC) to drive inward investments, entrepreneurship support and development.
- To cut obsolete, unnecessarily burdensome, and bureaucratic hurdles for small businesses.
- We shall establish cashew and cocoa processing factories in Owan federal constituency for the production of powder, chocolate and butter
- We shall establish a groundnut processing factory in Fugar
- To strengthen rural areas in the state by increasing rural broadband access for economic growth, educational opportunities, and healthcare access.

Multilateral non-concessional and concessional finance from international organizations, bilateral non-concessional and concessional finance from other governments (such as EU and other sources), and commercial finance (from banks, capital market bonds, and public-private partnership finance) will **ONLY** be entered into if it is beneficial to Edo people and will not jeopardize public financing in the near or longer term. The practice of irresponsible and unwarranted borrowing that could mortgage the future of Edo will be discontinued.

- A furniture-manufacturing cluster that will combine workshop units, factory spaces, large-scale manufacturing facilities as well as a retail unit for business-to-business and business-to-consumer sales in one location will be established in Egor/Ikpoba-Okha axis.
- We will establish a garment-manufacturing cluster.
- We will exploit the growing demand for African clothes abroad and make our state a major exporter of well-designed African fabrics.
- The state is blessed with abundant solid minerals like limestone, which is the major raw material in cement production. Other mineral resources available include iron ore, gold, marble, granite, gypsum, lignite, bitumen, ceramic clay, kaolin, dolomite, feldspar, bentonite and silicon sand used in the production of glass. All these can be commercially exploited through PPP.
- A Solid minerals cluster will also be created in Edo North to cater for those in the chemical and allied industry; while the fruit growers in Uhunmwode and Orhionmwon Local Government Areas will also be encouraged.
- Edo Central, which is renowned for rice, will play host to the grain cluster. The Agro-Cluster will be established in a central location to take care of the plantain and other farm produce.
- Our government will work with the Edo State Chambers of Commerce and Industry to provide support, information, business startups and growth capacity enhancement programmes across the three senatorial districts.
- Our government will partner with stakeholders, banks and other financial institutions to resuscitate and revamp the state owned industries including the Fertilizer plant, Auchi; Cassavita Factory, Uromi; Ava Cement Factory, Akoko-Edo; Fruit Juice Factory, Ehor; Bendel Brewery, Benin to mention but a few. This policy would create additional 3000 direct jobs and sustain over **5,000** related jobs in the economy.

2) Transport

- We shall liaise with the Federal government in partnership with private investors to expand or relocate the Benin Airport in order to meet the demands of the imminent industrial revolution in the state.
- We shall prioritize the development of the Uzairue Airport in Edo North senatorial district as a strategic infrastructural investment.
- Our government will partner with stakeholders and investors to develop all sea routes linking Edo State with other states.

- To facilitate this process, government will form a consortium with sound and tested partners and investors in collaboration with the Federal Government to dredge the Gelegele River and make it a viable modern seaport. This policy will create over 50,000 new jobs and with improved roads, light grid, bridges and water, a seaport can force a number of new cities to spring forth.
- Our government will also seek technical partners and investors to develop and extend railway lines to the three senatorial districts. This would help to provide a transportation solution for investment and trade.
- The Benin bypass and Okene-Auchi-Benin highway are some of the strategic roads that we would actively engage the Federal Government to complete without further delay. The Benin bypass is one of the most significant developments in the state even if its full potential in terms of promoting industrialization was not envisioned. Aside the two Chinese firms producing ceramic tiles and iron rods, we will encourage other companies to establish there.
- The Sapele road to Oluku axis of the bypass needs to be completed having been partially awarded to an indigenous contractor in 2009.
- We will establish two modern trailer parks (complete with workshops, gas stations, rest rooms and catering facilities) for articulated vehicles – one at Oluku-Ore road and the other at Aviele, along Benin-Auchi Road to deal with the problem of indiscriminate highway parking and its attendant road risks.
- We are committed to effective alleviation of poverty and financial hardship across board and in pursuance of this goal, we shall provide free public transportation (via public buses) for children in primary and secondary schools.
- Edo line will be revived and made fully operational while Edo City Transport Service (ECTS) will be strengthened to cover more communities, so as to foster collective integration for all citizens.

(3) Taxation

Taxation is very important as a major source of internally generated revenue especially in the face of dwindling oil earnings. In the past years, a number of factors have been responsible for the low revenue yield in the state. Some include-

- Low investment in taxpayers' education and sensitization;
- Absence of a comprehensive and reliable data base to capture all taxpayers (specifically in the informal sector and the affluent) into the tax net;
- Leakages and lack of full disclosures in the system leading to fraud, diversions, under-assessments, evasion, connivance, outright embezzlement, etc. of tax revenues);
- Lack of political will to implement legal and enforcement framework;
- Tax payer apathy (low morale and poor voluntary compliance arising from corruption and poor service delivery by successive governments;
- Institutional inefficiencies – monitoring, supervision logistic, and manpower challenges;
- Documentation, transparency and accountability problems; and
- Poor target setting amongst others.

To curb these, we shall:

- Diversify the economy and concentrate on wealth creation in services that will make Edo State more competitive, like other viable States in the country.
- Revenue planning must be instituted. It will provide the ground for effective and all-inclusive revenue generation.
- Deliberate efforts must be made to drive and utilize modern technology in every sector of the economy.
- The State must be committed to the setting up and implementation of a Treasury Single Account (TSA). Apart from raising the prospect of transparency in government finances, the single account being proposed would assist the state to administer and effectively manage the lean resources at its disposal.
- To expand the tax net, there is the need to develop a very comprehensive and reliable database of all commercial activities in the state. Such database would provide critical information about the locations, categories and incomes of taxpayers.
- The higher the level of education and consistency in enlightenment of taxpayers about the importance of taxation for development and payment terms and conditions, the more the likelihood of voluntary compliance to pay taxes and greater revenue yield. Therefore, investment in tax education should be top and first-line priority of State Internal Revenue Service and Local Governments Revenue Committees in their annual budgets.
- Legal enforcement to deter non-compliance at the State and Local Government levels will be carried out.
- Deliberate efforts must be made by the State and the Local Governments to handle the twin issues of collection inefficiencies and blocking of leakages to enhance their revenue take.
- Recommendations of various monitoring, verification and investigative exercises conducted over the years which have exposed significant levels of collection inefficiencies and leakages will be reviewed and implemented.
- Where Consultants are involved, their engagement should be restricted to supportive services such as research and database development, etc. This is necessary to avoid the existence of two parallel tax authorities.
- Revenue officers should undergo regular capacity building training to enable them cascade knowledge gained to their subordinates.
- ICT competence will be made a key qualification for new entrants into the State Internal Revenue Service to enable them cope with the dynamics of modern revenue generation, effective documentation and storage of revenue data (collections and remittances)
- Use reliable database in setting revenue targets to achieve maximum collection.
- The State's Bureau of Statistics should be re-positioned for data-driven development of all sectors. This is to pave way for proper planning. Remember, a society that cannot plan base on basic statistics is doom to survive.
- A proper, effective and achievable collaborative approach is key to modern revenue generation. Here, we shall partner with the Federal and Local Governments.

Nevertheless, we will stop the unnecessary duplication of taxes and review the present tax policy, which is harsh, punitive and discriminatory. With such a fair, transparent, innovative, and simpler tax regime, tax payers will be encouraged to comply.

(4) Diaspora Engagement

- We appreciate their contributions to our GDP and will open a diaspora desk in government to liaise with them. We shall open a database for them and encourage them to visit and return home. We shall provide adequate security for them and protect their investments.
- We will constructively engage with our citizens in Diaspora to harness the potentials in financial and intellectual investment targets. In particular, we will actively welcome their partnership in our public private sector engagement and collaboratively promote their offer to expand private philanthropy.
- We will set an investment target of 5000 hours per year in the area of medical missions, sport diplomacy, and other aspects of volunteer work. We will encourage and facilitate channels that will bring more intervention projects from the Diaspora such as the direct financing of local transparent businesses and green spring projects.
- We will organize a Diaspora Investment Forum and explore the opportunity of a Diaspora Bond. Adequate energy will be devoted to constructive partnership with the Edos in Diaspora.

5) Agriculture and Rural Development

Agriculture should be the mainstay of the Edo economy. The major food crops in the state include, maize, cassava, yam and banana, plantain, pineapple, livestock, cattle, the main cash crops include cocoa, kolanut, groundnut, tobacco, sugar cane, coconut, rubber, timber, cotton, palm oil, and palm kernels. Particularly, the state is one of the largest producers of rubber, timber and kolanut in the country. As a government, the centerpiece of the state's agricultural policy shall be the working out of modalities for expansion in the cultivation and production of these crops that are peculiar to the state all through their value chain and taking into consideration the comparative advantage of each location. In the process, we shall empower small-scale farmers and also promote commercial farming. Both sets of farmers will be supported with certified high yield seeds or stocks, effective rural development, rural infrastructure, stable energy supply, agricultural credit, marketing and processing arrangements, research and training backup, and quality control. The agricultural policy will create and expand job opportunities through the entire agricultural value chain.

Impact will be in:

- Production and supply of agricultural inputs.
- Production of food and fiber for man and industries respectively.
- Processing and value addition.
- Packaging and marketing.
- Production of the local raw materials for the industrial sector
- ✓ Young graduates and school leavers will be trained as “agripreneurs” to take advantage of the opportunities in any aspect of the agricultural value chain.

- ✓ Seed multiplication farms- livestock and fish breeding centres will be established under Public Private Partnership (PPP) to facilitate access to high yielding and disease resistant inputs, livestock (breeding stock) and fingerlings.
- ✓ Urban agriculture shall be an integral part of this policy to train service providers and utilize fallow lands in urban areas.
- ✓ We will improve village level infrastructure in terms of roads, potable water, education, health, supply chain, electricity, ICT, job creation, security in rural areas and linkage to agro markets. The overall objective is to stem the tide of rural-urban drift.
- The use of agriculture as a vehicle for economic development and job creation.
- Improvement of the livelihoods of the host communities through access to microcredit scheme and other Local Economic Development (LED) programmes.
- Production of high-yielding crops
- Setting up of farm settlements, complete with training institutes, processing facilities, tractors, and in-farm housing units in each of the three senatorial districts, with the sole intent to produce for local and international markets will be set up.
- Diversifying and boosting the state's revenue base through proceeds from agricultural produce.
- Creation of special units for packaging for export in order to earn foreign exchange
- Encouragement of young graduates and school leavers to cultivate the required raw materials for the agro-processing factories to be established in different parts of the State.
- Revamping of abandoned farms and ranches such as Urhonigbe Rubber Factory, Leventis Farms, Warrake Farms, the Igarra Cattle Ranch, Ubiaja Goat Farms, and where necessary, creation of new ones.
- The establishment of an integrated Rural Development Programme designed to be complemented by auxiliary small- scale businesses with high job creation capacity.
- Deployment of the existing micro-credit schemes in conjunction with the Banks of Industry and Agriculture to generate wealth and income for rural dwellers;
- Provision of agricultural extension services to farmers in the state.
- Setting up of an **Agricultural Investment Promotion Agency** that would serve as a link between the farmers and the market place to ensure regular flow of income through ready patronage and stabilization of commodity prices.
- Identification of the physically challenged and economically disadvantaged persons who are target beneficiaries of the new Micro Credit Scheme.
- The over **10,000** persons that will be empowered in the first one-year of the programme.
- Taking appropriate steps to key into the \$1 billion initiative of the African Development Bank (AFDB), Islamic Development Bank (IDB) and the International Fund for Agricultural development to deliver Special Agro-Industrial Processing Zones (**SAPZ**) in 24 states of Nigeria. A major beneficiary shall be the virgin forest between Ehor and Iruekpen on the Benin-Auchi express way amongst others. This program will transform agricultural practices, shifting the state from an agrarian to an industrial society centered around agribusiness.

The main areas the state will direct her attention in order to realize the above objectives are;

- A. Production of Rice-Upland and Lowland.
- B. Development of Poultry-Layers and broiler
- C. Livestock fattening program
- D. Rehabilitation of government-owned rubber plantation at Urhonigbe
- E. Development of large-scale nurseries for the supply of oil palm, cocoa and cashew seedlings.
- F. Development of homestead and artisanal fisheries especially shrimps at Gelegele areas for export. Edo State has unique shrimps that are highly priced in the world market.
- G. Market Gardening/Horticultural crops production.
- H. Agricultural marketing Board/Company to bulk-purchase from farms and stores to resell.
- I. Cassava seed farms.
- J. Cassava processing
- K. Medicinal plants production and processing
- L. Sugarcane cultivation

6. Culture and Tourism

The ultimate goal of our tourism economic programme will be to capitalize on the centrality of the state to develop 'BRAND EDO', which will be built around entertainment, as well as our historical and cultural heritage. Tourism's main comparative advantage over other sectors is that visitors' expenditure has a "flow-through" or catalytic effect across the economy in terms of production and employment creation which will help mitigate the rampant incidence of human trafficking and the japa syndrome. . Tourism economic activities will also help to booster other sectors such as retail, rental, hiring, real estate, arts, recreational and a range of others services that contribute to economic activities. Tourism investment can generate the demand for locally produced foods, clothing, art and craft, furniture and furnishings, and capital equipment. Tourism also generates the demand for transport, telecommunication, and financial services.

In order to bring back the glory of our beloved state, we shall employ renewed ideas and strategic partnerships with experienced local and international stakeholders in the following areas:

- i. Development of Edo Tourism Master-Plan
- ii. Organization of an annual Benin Carnival
- iii. Creation of Tourism Development Zones
- iv. Convocation of Edo State Tourism Summit
- v. Creation of tourism Clusters
- vi. Identification of tourist Destinations across the state
- vii. Reclamation and Development of tourism Assets
- viii. Classification of tourist services
- ix. Local, regional and international marketing programs
- x. Convocation of Annual Bronze Festival in Benin City.
- xi. Creation of holiday resorts located in sprawling environments of several hectares. This will attract big players like Hilton, Marriott and Disney. In the process we shall attract huge investments opportunities through venture capital to the state.

- xii. We shall create the Edo State Tourism Bureau, which will operate independent of government bureaucracy to allow for operational efficiency, professionalism and global standards.
- xiii. We shall critically work on developing health, education and sports tourism to make Edo State the tourism hub of Nigeria.
- xiv. We would develop a state-of-the-art film village to attract film producers, actresses, actors and other stakeholders in the entertainment industry to make films that would engender positive attitudinal changes in our youths. Thousands of jobs would be created in the process even as the creative energy of our youths will be uncorked.
- xv. We will collaborate with the Palace and support them financially and otherwise to erect a befitting **“Royal Museum”** that will meet international standards to showcase our returned artifacts and many more that our royal father and other traditional rulers may choose to exhibit. This gesture will make Edo an international tourist destination.
- xvi. Given the historical antecedents of our traditional institutions, they have an indisputable role in the promotion of the tourism industry in Edo state and in Nigeria in general if supported by the state government. Preceding administrations have hitherto not recognized this huge opportunity. Exploitation of the inherent potentials in this sector will see these institutions making a significant contribution to the GDP of Edo state. Hence, the state government shall support ongoing efforts by these institutions in enhancing the tourism potentials of the state. This action in addition to the preservation and promotion of our bronze casting skills, and other cultural events yet to be identified, should contribute immensely to the tourism industry.
- xvii. The Edo state government shall also provide resources for the preservation, maintenance and development of infrastructure holding traditional socio-cultural (and economic) values in terms of buildings, facilities, monuments, historical sites such as moats, e.t.c., for the promotion of the cultural values of Edo people and for other tourism and socio-economic benefits.
- xviii. We shall protect, promote and preserve the Traditional Heritages of Edo people

7. Markets

Our agricultural products are highly sought after everywhere. Traders in other parts of Nigeria in trying to convince their customers are quick to say- “it is Edo garri, Edo banana, Edo plantain, Edo palm oil, or it is bush meat and snail from Edo state”. We will take advantage of this and make the state an economic hub for our local farmers and traders. As a farmer, I can tell that the opportunities are limitless.

However, most of our markets are in terrible conditions lacking conveniences and safety. Hence, the need to rethink the way they are built and the process of management. We would develop strategic partnerships with credible and renowned investors for the sake of constructing ultra-modern, as well as specialized markets for our people. We would ensure that space standards, choice of materials, structures that take cognizance of the environment as well as the fire service form the basics of the new Edo markets. We shall also encourage through PPP the construction of Shopping malls in major centres across the state.

L: LEADERSHIP BY EXAMPLE

"If your actions inspire others to dream more, learn more, do more and become more, you are a leader" - John Quincy Adams

High moral value in the conduct of state business at all times, demonstrating discipline and leadership by example that is guided by transparency and accountability in order to restore confidence in the government will be established. Parts of the measures to be adopted include:

- An Administrative Reform through the 'Open Government and Accountable Administration' (OGAA). We shall insist on transparency, due process, accountability and competitive bidding in all government contracts.
- There shall be quick acceleration of public request seeking information from the government under the Freedom of Information Act (FOI).
- There shall be display of great foresight at all times in matters of governance and the ability to identify and solve societal problems in manners that are transparent, creative and decisive.
- Emphasis on technology-enabled e-governance as a direct step to eliminate incidences of institutional corruption, as well as the modification of the tax regime as solution to the problem of corruption in the tax system.
- We shall respect the autonomy of the three arms of government, namely, the executive, legislature and the judicial and shall ensure their development, welfare and efficiency.
- We find the continuous abolition of the Edo State Customary Court of Appeal ill conceived. We shall definitely review this act and respect the rule of law.
- We shall have zero tolerance for corruption and associated vices and will encourage whistle-blower protection. To this end, we shall promote citizens' participation in decision making and establish an open and accessible government.
- There shall be regular town hall meetings with relevant stakeholders as a way of bringing government closer to the people as well as a quarterly briefing on government activities by relevant heads of MDAs.
- Promote gender equality and women's rights by engendering Sustainable Development Goals agenda that is capable of eradicating gender-based violence
- Promote the participation of women in decision making, spur them to take up leadership roles while advancing their economic justice in the process.
- Create cooperatives across the state, which will give loans to market women and farmers so as to increase productivity.
- There will be investment in long-term social and cultural change, including the engagement of faith leaders and faith-based organizations, and ensuring that support is available to NGOs working to tackle discriminatory social norms.
- We will actively engage the NGOs in all areas of governance, support their activities and collaborate with them on policy formulation and implementation.
- We intend to ensure strict supervision of council resources and expenditure. We shall however encourage financial autonomy of the local government councils and create Local Government Development Areas to fast track the development of these areas.

- We will also give freedom to Local Government Councils to function in accordance with their mandates and protect local government council chairmen from executive intimidation, constant harassment and unwarranted removal.
- We appreciate the invaluable role of our traditional institutions ably led by our royal majesty, the Oba of Benin and we intend to strengthen their offices while also ensuring improvement in their welfare.
- We will run an inclusive and continuous consultative government by listening to public opinions, views and suggestions. We will use "Edo Policy Exchange" and Town Hall meetings to engage, consult and elicit innovative ideas so as to move Edo State forward.
- We shall be receptive to the yearnings of party members who differ in opinion and respect the party hierarchy and its leaders.

E EMPLOYMENT CREATION & SOCIAL EMPOWERMENT

With the **"SIMPLE"** Agenda, we will create an enabling business environment in the state, that can attract honest investors to take advantage of all our PPP initiatives. Thousands of jobs will be created through the following government activities:

- In the execution of the various programs of the **"SIMPLE"** Agenda, job creation components and sustainability thereof will be the critical factor in measuring performance and success.
- The goal of **"SIMPLE"** Agenda is to generate jobs from programs, projects and activities in each of the 18 Local Government Areas.
- For the PPP industrial schemes in each of the senatorial districts, it is reckoned that each of the clusters should be capable of accommodating up to 10 separate industrial firms and would give direct employment opportunities to well over 3,000 persons and another 5,000 persons indirectly, providing the raw materials, goods and services, across the state.
- It is also planned to attract over 5,000 persons to the Farm Settlement, while at the same time, Youth Empowerment through Agricultural and Farmer's Support Programme (**YETA-FSP**) will be established to support 500 youths from each of the 18 LGAs every year.
- The **"SIMPLE"** agenda will encourage and organize the business activities of host communities through the Ministry of Oil and Gas to benefit from our 'Local Content Opportunity' policy in the strategic industries of Power Generation, Oil and Gas, and Solid Minerals in line with existing federal government regulations.
- The Graduate Youth Entrepreneurial Scheme and other Micro-Credit Schemes will be redesigned and supported with matching grants from the state government and other financial development institutions such as the Bank of Industry, Bank of Agriculture, **SMEDAN** e.t.c. This is aimed at creating additional jobs.
- We shall collaborate with and support our communities in establishing agro-allied industries to drive our Youth Empowerment Programs.
- Cleanliness and Sanitation will be given priority. Thus, an efficient Waste Management System to be set up will involve integrated waste management infrastructure which has the capacity to provide over 5,000 jobs by the service providers

- Edo State has a very potent mining industry that has remained grossly unexploited in actualizing its full benefits. This area will be a key focus in the creation of jobs.
- We understand and fully recognize the role of SMEs as the engine of any economy. Our vision will be to make Edo State the best place for businesses to start and thrive. To do this we need to understand the characteristics of our small and medium sized businesses, what determines their success and what holds them back.
- While we emphasize the up-skilling and building of human capacity, we shall improve all aspects of financing and access to finance by SMEs through deliberative actions and interventions. A key priority will be to unleash the energy of the entrepreneurial spirit of Edo people who are known to be innovators of new and nascent industries.
- We recognize and salute the role of financial organizations that have been able to mobilize funds for our low-income people to access and trade and we intend to partner with these institutions by providing more funds to support more of our people.
- One of government's policy goals is to partner with financial institutions, banks, agencies of government and stakeholders to create and support a minimum of 5000 new MSMEs in the economy yearly and 20,000 over a four-year duration.

However, the sustainability of any innovation or change is based on either the country-culture, state-culture or organizational-culture. The state government in collaboration with the state chapter of the National Orientation Agency will come up with ethical ways of doing business, of conducting oneself in the society, and having a positive attitude towards public properties and projects. When the culture of a populace is taken into consideration, any innovation or improvement that is suggested will be sustained. One of the best ways to drive this cultural change is to lead transparently by example, develop simple phrases that will be duplicated in government offices, so as to reinforce compliance. Government will have to take stock of its properties and set aside maintenance costs, as there is no point in embarking on new projects if the old ones cannot be maintained. The Nigerian polity lacks a maintenance culture. This undesirable habit must change.

CONCLUSION

We are optimistic that in spite of the dark clouds fueled by political intolerance and corruption, the future of our state is bright. What is needed to promote greater development and prosperity for the state is to enthrone sincere, focused, purposeful and visionary leadership. The **"SIMPLE Agenda"** addresses the issues of our state in a simple and straightforward manner so that our people can be kept abreast of the developmental processes of government in a logical and systematic fashion. As such, our performances can be measured and the results seen. We solemnly pledge that we will not betray the expectations of our people but will work diligently with the fear of God.

My fellow citizens of Edo state, guided by this agenda, I am committed to serve you with the passion, dedication, integrity, urgency and the dexterity that the state of Edo currently requires. We urge you all to trust us and vote for our party, the **APC**, in the forthcoming Edo State Gubernatorial elections and together, we will transform our beloved state into a model for societal development.

May God bless you;

May God bless Edo State;

May God bless the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

#ForABetterTomorrow

